Deficiency



Figure 9.7: Potassium deficiency symptoms

Deficiency of potassium leads to depression in cardiac and nervous system. Severe vomiting, diarrhoea, loss of appetite, fasting or starvation over a long period of time may lead to deficiency of potassium. It also occurs during renal failure and shock. Fatigue, growth retardation, muscular weakness, heart and respiratory dysfunction are common signs of potassium deficiency.

9.2.5. Chlorine

Chlorine is taken in diet as sodium chloride. Chloride is the major anion in the extracellular fluid.

Functions:

1. Chloride plays a vital role in acid-base balance by way of chloride shift and maintains blood pH.

2. Chlorides also contribute to formation of gastric HCl.

3. It also helps to maintain plasma osmotic pressure.

4. Chloride ion is important as an activator of salivary amylase.

5. Chloride mainly acts as a counter ion against cations in maintaining the electrical neutrality in body fluids.

Sources

Table salt (Sodium chloride) is the main source of chloride.

Absorption and excretion:

Chloride is completely absorbed from the gastro intestinal tract. Chloride is mainly eliminated in the urine and also in the sweat.

Deficiency

Deficiency states of chloride are rare. Most often, sodium and chloride are associated with each other in their functions. Any clinical condition like dehydration, affecting sodium concentration has an identical effect on chloride concentration.

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